

Genre

While the word 'genre' can mean a 'type' of art, such as portrait, landscape or still life, 'genre painting' specifically describes often-intimate scenes of everyday life, featuring ordinary people working or relaxing, in mundane environments such as domestic interiors, social gatherings or inn and street scenes. It is generally realistic and unsentimental.

Early examples appear in ancient art, but the term was first used in 18th-century France to describe domestic scenes painted by 17th-century Dutch artists such as Jan Steen and Dirck Hals (1591–1656). Dirck, Frans Hals's younger brother, painted 'merry company' scenes, often also called 'conversation pieces'. In France, the peasant scenes of Le Nain brothers are sometimes classed as genre paintings, as are some works by Jean-Baptiste-Siméon Chardin (1699–1779), particularly his kitchen maids, children and domestic activities. In England, William Hogarth's comical, moralizing narrative scenes of ordinary people were particularly popular among the bourgeois.



Steen, *The Merry Family*, 1668